

How does anarchism typically die

21 June 2026 · revising

Anarchism is often dismissed as never having been tried. It has — repeatedly, at real scale, governing millions of people. The pattern worth noticing is not that it never works, but *how* it ends.

The 23 cases in the appendix below are too few for statistics, but enough for a shape. Sort them by cause of death and one bar dwarfs the rest.

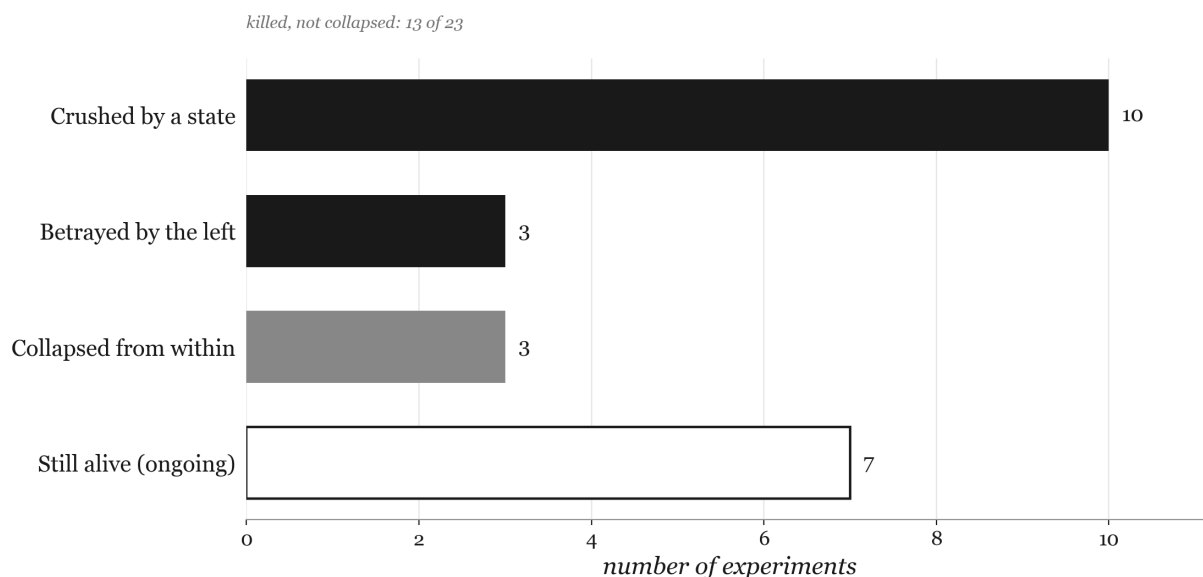


Figure 2: How the 23 anarchist experiments ended, tallied by cause: crushed by a state dwarfs the rest, while collapse-from-within is rare.

Of the 16 experiments that ended, only 3 actually *collapsed* from within. The other 13 were killed — 10 crushed by an enemy state, 3 betrayed by the authoritarian left they had fought alongside. The remaining 7 are still alive, and nearly all of them are small.

That inverts the usual obituary. Anarchism is supposed to fail because it cannot scale — because without a state it dissolves into chaos. But collapse-from-within is the rarest ending on the chart. Anarchism rarely dies of its own contradictions; it gets murdered, usually by a state, and at its largest by the left. The betrayals are few, but they land on the giants: the two largest experiments ever recorded, Makhno’s Free Territory and revolutionary Catalonia, were destroyed not by their declared enemies but by the Bolsheviks and Stalinists nominally on their side.

There is a sharper catch. The big modern cases anarchists point to — Rojava, Oaxaca, Cherán — are mostly broad popular fronts or indigenous autonomies that anarchists *joined* rather than authored. Strip those out and unmistakably anarchist self-government at scale almost vanishes from the record. The most unforgiving reading: large anarchism does not merely die young — it is rarely permitted to exist at all. Whether the small survivors represent endurance or surrender is the open question.

Appendix

The full record behind the chart, sorted by peak scale.

The **bold** phrase in *How it ended* is the load-bearing claim each source is cited for — the manner of death (or survival) that the chart and the central argument rest on. Start there when checking a reference.

† *Anarchist-**influenced** rather than anarchist-led — a popular front, indigenous communalism, or worker-cooperative movement that anarchists took part in or claim, rather than a card-carrying anarchist polity. Iceland is older and shakier still: it is cited mostly by anarcho-capitalists and is here only as the one pre-modern outlier.*

Experiment	Where / when	Scale	Death	How it ended	Source
Revolutionary Catalonia & Aragon	Spain, 1936–1939	≈5–8 million in collectives	Be-trayed	Undermined by Stalinist allies , then defeated by Franco	source
Free Territory (Makhnovshchina)	Ukraine, 1918–1921	Up to ≈7 million	Be-trayed	Used then liquidated by the Bolsheviks once the Whites were beaten	source
Rojava (AANES)	North-east Syria, 2012–present	≈2–4 million	Alive	Survives under constant military threat from Turkey and others	source
Hungarian workers' councils	Hungary, 1956	Millions, briefly	Crushed	Crushed by Soviet tanks within weeks	source
Paris Commune	Paris, 1871	≈2 million	Crushed	Crushed by the French Army ; ≈20,000 killed in the <i>semaine sanglante</i>	source
Korean People's Association	Manchuria, 1929–1931	≈2 million	Crushed	Caught between Japanese imperial forces and Stalinists	source
Biennio Rosso	Italy, 1919–1920	≈600,000 workers	Collapsed	Collapsed ; cleared the path for Fascist reaction	source
Bavarian Council Republic †	Munich, 1919	≈600,000	Crushed	Stormed by the Freikorps ; Landauer murdered	source
Bakur self-rule †	South-east Turkey, 2015–2016	≈400,000	Crushed	Turkish army sieges ; districts levelled, trustees imposed	source
Zapatistas (EZLN)	Chiapas, Mexico, 1994–present	≈300,000	Alive	Survives , encircled and pressured by the Mexican state	source
Oaxaca Commune (APPO) †	Oaxaca, Mexico, 2006	≈200,000	Crushed	Federal police retook the city centre	source
Icelandic Commonwealth	Iceland, 930–1262	≈50,000	Collapsed	Collapsed into feuding chieftains ; absorbed by Norway	source
Strandzha Commune	Ottoman Thrace, 1903	Tens of thousands	Crushed	Crushed by the Ottoman army after ≈20 days	source
Kronstadt Soviet	Russia, 1921	≈18,000	Be-trayed	Stormed by the Red Army ; rebels executed or exiled	source
Cherán †	Michoacán, Mexico, 2011–present	≈16,000	Alive	Survives , legally recognised indigenous autonomy	source
Recovered factories †	Argentina, 2001–present	≈16,000 workers	Alive	Survives , pressured under the Milei government	source
Alcoy insurrection	Alcoy, Spain, 1873	≈10,000	Crushed	Retaken by the federal army within days	source
Exarcheia	Athens, 1970s–present	Thousands	Alive	Survives , under ongoing police eviction pressure	source

Experiment	Where / when	Scale	Death	How it ended	Source
Magonista Baja California	Mexico, 1911	Thousands	Crushed	Defeated by federal troops; the PLM suppressed	source
Alt Llobregat rising	Catalonia, Spain, 1932	≈3,000	Crushed	Retaken by army and Civil Guard; militants deported	source
CHAZ / CHOP	Seattle, USA, 2020	A few thousand	Collapsed	Collapsed in ≈3 weeks; cleared by police	source
Marinaleda	Spain, 1979–present	≈2,700	Alive	Survives as a functioning cooperative	source
Christiania Freetown	Copenhagen, 1971–present	≈1,000	Alive	Survives, semi-legalised, under constant property pressure	source